

# CRIME AND PUNISHMENT



A CRIME IS A FORBIDDEN ACT, punished by law because it may harm a society or injure its members. The type of act that is considered a crime varies from culture to culture, changing as societies and attitudes develop. For example, in some parts of the Middle East, it is a crime to drink alcohol, but a man may have more than one wife. In the United States, alcohol is not illegal, but having more than one wife is against the law.



Murder

## Crime against the person

When one person intentionally kills another, this is known as murder. It is a crime against the person, and does not respect the individual's right to live his or her life without fear of attack and violence. Assault, rape, and kidnapping are other such crimes. Killing someone in self-defence (to protect your own life), or killing an enemy of one's country in times of war, is not considered to be murder.

## Types of crimes

Some acts, such as murder and theft, have been crimes in all civilized societies for thousands of years, and are known as *malum in se* (the Latin phrase for "bad in themselves"). Other crimes, such as driving an unregistered or untaxed car, are known as *malum prohibitum* (bad because the law says so).

## Crime against property

Laws exist to protect people's right to own property. It is a criminal act to take or damage the property of another against the owner's wishes. Examples of such crimes include theft, forgery, arson, and vandalism.



Silverware



Antiques



Jewellery



Jewellery



Electrical goods



Stolen property

## Prison

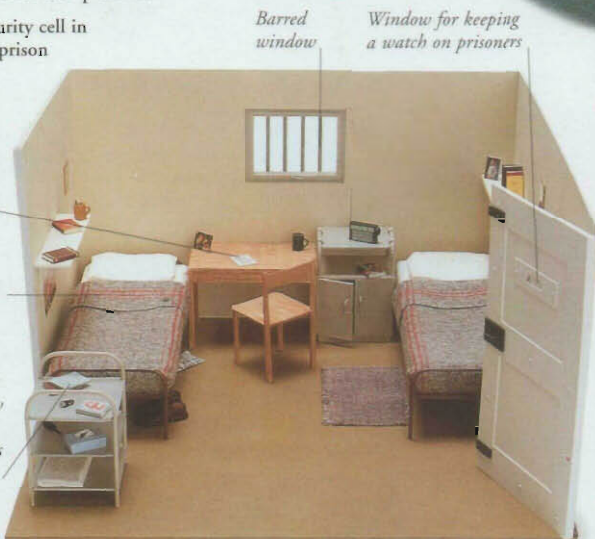
Someone who commits a crime may be sent to prison for a length of time which reflects the seriousness of the offence. Prison is mainly a punishment, but it also offers criminals a chance to reform. It acts to deter other people from crime and keeps dangerous criminals away from the public.

### High-security cell in a British prison

Prisoners can send only one letter a week.

Simply furnished

Inmates can bring only a few personal belongings to prison.



Barred window

Window for keeping a watch on prisoners

Men and women go to separate prisons. As inmates, they may spend as much as 23 hours a day locked in their cells, which they usually share with one or two others. They must wear prison uniforms.



### Alcatraz

A maximum-security prison was built on the island of Alcatraz in San Francisco Bay, USA. It was in use from 1933 to 1963; in that time, not one prisoner escaped alive. Of the 23 that tried, five were shot dead, six drowned, and 12 were recaptured.

### High-security cell

Criminals convicted of serious crimes are sent to high-security prisons. Inmates are only allowed to leave their cells to eat, work, or for study programmes. People who commit lesser crimes may be sent to open prisons, where they have more freedom.

## Organized crime

Organized crime consists of large-scale activities by groups of gangsters, sometimes known as the underworld. They make much of their money by providing illegal goods, including drugs, and services, such as gambling or prostitution.

### Crime syndicates

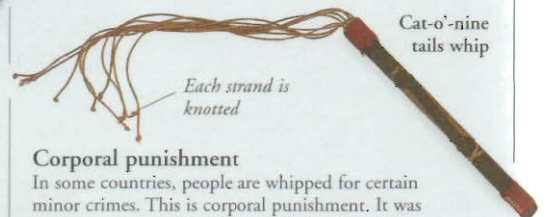
Secret criminal organizations exist across the world, such as the Mafia, which first originated centuries ago in Sicily. During the 1920s a powerful crime syndicate grew up in Chicago, USA, run by brutal gangsters, such as the notorious Al Capone (1899–1947).



Al Capone

## Punishment

Theories about punishment have developed since the 18th century when even minor offences were harshly punished to deter others from committing crime. Around the world, law-breakers are punished in various ways: in the UK, for instance, criminals are usually fined, or sent to prison.



Cat-o'-nine tails whip

Each strand is knotted

### Corporal punishment

In some countries, people are whipped for certain minor crimes. This is corporal punishment. It was once common, and beatings took place in public as a warning to deter others from crime.



Electric chair

### Capital punishment

The ultimate penalty for a crime is death, or capital punishment. Hanging, gassing, and the electric chair are some of the methods that have been used. Many people now argue that mistakes can be made and that capital punishment is morally wrong. In the USA, this issue is hotly debated; many other Western nations have abolished the death penalty.

Bronze cat from ancient Egypt, dedicated to the cat goddess Bastet.



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